ATTACK ON USS COLE

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Date October 12, 2000
Forces Americans: 1 destroyer; terrorists: 1 suicide boat
Losses Americans: 1 destroyer damaged; terrorists: 1 suicide boat sunk

Location Port of Aden, Yemen

On October 12, 2000, the Arleigh Burke-class guided-missile destroyer USS *Cole* made a routine refueling stop in Aden Harbor, Yemen. The *Cole* was a very new addition to the US Navy arsenal. She had been launched in 1996 and was equipped with the latest Aegis integrated guided weapons system. The Middle East was a potentially dangerous part of the world for the ship and its crew, but Aden was classed as a relatively safe harbor. The ship had been refuelling for some 50 minutes when, at 11:18 a.m., a speedboat made an approach to the port side of the destroyer, piloted by two men. The vessel seemed to present no threat; indeed, many of the US sailors thought that it was the local garbage collection boat. Yet on board the speedboat was a large quantity of explosives, which the suicide bombers then detonated against the side of the ship.

Waterline blast
A gaping 35 ft (10.6 m) hole mars the side of USS *Cole*. The ship was carried back to the US for repairs aboard a heavy transport ship.



The explosion ripped open the port side of the *Cole*; its force was directed into the galley area, where many men where lining up to eat, killing 17 and injuring another 39.

AFTERMATH

Although the keel of the vessel was not significantly damaged, water poured into the ship through the open hull, and it took the whole day to bring the flooding under control. The first naval assistance to the *Cole* came in from the Royal Navy Type-23 frigate HMS *Marlborough*, which was sailing through the Gulf and diverted to provide medical and engineering aid. A force of US Marines arrived shortly afterward to provide additional security.

The bombing was planned by the Al-Qaeda terrorist group and carried out by operatives most likely acting with the support of Sudanese officials. The US Navy subsequently changed its rules of engagement—which had prevented the ship's guards firing on the approaching boat—to protect US vessels from similar attacks. Nonetheless, the bombing was a grim reminder of the vulnerability of modern warships, however well defended against conventional attack, to small vessels posing as non-combatants.



USS Cole limps home
The damaged destroyer is towed out of Aden by a Military Sealift Command tug before returning to the United States for repairs lasting 14 months.

"WAR ON TERROR"

INVASION OF AFGHANISTAN



Date 2001–
Forces Coalition forces: unknown; Afghans: none
Losses Coalition forces: none; Afghans: none

Location Persian Gulf and Afghanistan

The invasion of Afghanistan by US, UK, and Coalition forces in 2001—named Operation Enduring Freedom—presented significant problems in terms of air support. Afghanistan is a land-locked country with no substantial infrastructure, hence there was little in the way of Forward Operating Bases (FOBs) for Allied aircraft. For much of the early part of the campaign, therefore, air support was almost exclusively provided by US Navy and Marine Corps aviation operating from carrier battle groups in the Gulf. The attack sorties ran in over Pakistan (Iran was, and remains, prohibited airspace) to bomb enemy bunkers and positions, the great distance to the inland target leaving scant time for loitering over the target. Only once the US Air Force began deploying heavy bombers to Diego Garcia, a British overseas territory in the Indian Ocean, did responsibility for the attacks become shared. Today the US Marine Corps (USMC) deploys aviation combat elements to support its ground forces on operations, deploying from FOBs established since the invasion.

US Marine and Navy aircraft were also integral to the invasion itself. The Marine Corps force that established the first strategic base in Afghanistan, for example, deployed Marine helicopters from the amphibious assault ships *Peleliu* and *Boxer*. The US Navy and USMC continue to provide support operations to ground troops, particularly as the US Marine Corps has been so heavily in demand for the ground fighting.

9-11 Let's Roll
Crew members assemble on the deck of amphibious assault ship USS *Belleau Wood* to remember the September 2001 terrorist attacks on New York, the catalyst for the invasion of Afghanistan.

